

CITI SUMMER INTERNSHIP INTERVIEW EXPERIENCE

Company & Role Overview

- **Company:** Citi (Citigroup) is a leading global financial services company headquartered in New York. Founded in 1812, it offers a wide range of services including banking, investment banking, and wealth management to individuals, corporations, and governments in over 100 countries.
- **Role Offered:** International Clients Group (ICG) Technology
- **Other Role:** Personal Banking & Wealth Management Technology (PBWMT)
- **Stipend:** ₹75,000 per month
- **Internship Duration:** 8 weeks

Selection Process

1. Online Assessment
2. Technical Interview
3. HR Interview

Round 1: Online Assessment (September 27, 2024)

The online test was 90 minutes long and consisted of four sections.

Important Note: It was not possible to switch between sections; they had to be completed in the order they were presented.

Test Structure:

- **Coding:** 2 questions (45 minutes)
- **SQL MCQs:** 12 questions (15 minutes)
- **React MCQs:** 12 questions (15 minutes)
- **Angular MCQs:** 12 questions (15 minutes)

Section Details:

- **Coding Questions** - The questions were considered easy and were based on arrays.

- **SQL Questions**
 - The difficulty level was easy to medium.
- **React & Angular JS Questions**
 - These multiple-choice sections included questions about finding missing terms and identifying correct code statements.

Following the online assessment, 28 candidates were shortlisted for the next round of interviews for the ICG Technology role.

Round 2: Technical Interview (Duration: 1 hour)

The interview began with my introduction. I structured it to highlight my favourite subjects and fields of interest, specifically mentioning my proficiency in Database Management Systems (DBMS). This led the interviewer to start with questions about my DBMS project.

Project 1: DBMS & Backend

- **Project Explanation:** I spent about 10 minutes clearly explaining my project. Since I mentioned handling the backend and database, the interviewer asked for more details. I gave him an overview of the backend operations, including how my PHP scripts worked and interacted with the database.
- **Database Schema:** He then asked me to explain my database schema. I detailed the structure of each table and explained the reasoning behind my normalization choices. This was followed by a question about the foreign key relationships I had implemented.
- **On-the-Spot Database Design:** The interviewer then proposed a new project idea and asked me to design a database for it.
 - I started by asking clarifying questions to understand the project's requirements and finalize the necessary tables.
 - I designed each table with relevant columns and constraints, periodically checking in with the interviewer to ensure my understanding was correct.
 - After structuring the tables, he asked me to normalize the design. I explained my normalization strategy and justified my decisions.
 - Finally, he asked me to add foreign key relationships where needed, and I identified and included one.

- **SQL Queries:** To conclude this section, he asked me to write several SQL queries for the database we had just designed. The queries primarily involved the use of JOINS and subqueries.

Frontend & Other Technologies

- **React/Angular:** The interviewer asked if I knew React or Angular. I was honest and stated that I was not very familiar with them.
- **HTML/CSS Task:** He then roughly sketched a webpage design and asked me to write the basic HTML and CSS for it, which I did.

Project 2: Python (DSA)

- The discussion moved to my second project, which was written in Python and involved data structures and algorithms.
- **Shortest Path Algorithm:** The project used a shortest-path algorithm. He asked which one I implemented, and I replied that I used Dijkstra's algorithm.
- He followed up by asking why I chose Dijkstra's over other algorithms. I explained my reasoning and then named other shortest-path algorithms I knew, such as Bellman-Ford, explaining each one briefly.

General CS Fundamentals

- **Java:** He asked about my experience with Java. I explained that I was currently learning it as part of my semester coursework but was not yet proficient.
- **Sorting Algorithms:** He then asked if I knew sorting algorithms. I said yes, and he specifically asked me to explain Radix Sort. I told him I was more familiar with Merge Sort and Quick Sort. He then asked me to explain Quick Sort, which I did with a diagram and an example.
- **Data Structures:** The interviewer presented a scenario and asked which data structure I would use to solve it. I suggested a Queue, explained my reasoning, and compared it with other data structures to justify why it was the most suitable choice.
- **Object-Oriented Programming (OOP):** Finally, he asked if I knew OOP concepts. I had prepared a concise, 10-minute explanation with a strong example, which I delivered clearly. He was impressed and appreciated how well I explained it.

Conclusion & Feedback

At the end of the interview, he asked if I had any questions for him. I had prepared two in advance:

1. **"How did I perform in the interview?"**
 - He responded, *"You are strong in what you know, and you know your strengths."*
2. **"What areas should I improve on?"**
 - He answered, *"There is nothing you should improve; you are good. However, it would be helpful for your career in the industry to get to know more technologies like React and Angular."*

Round 3: HR Interview

This was the final stage. Although it felt like a casual conversation, it was also an elimination round. The interview lasted for about 15-20 minutes.

To my surprise, I was called in 9th out of the 11 candidates, even though I was second on the shortlist. When I entered, the HR manager mentioned he did this intentionally to see if waiting would make me nervous.

Interview Discussion & Questions

The conversation covered a mix of standard HR questions and personal topics:

- **Knowledge about Citi:** He asked what I knew about the company. I shared information I had gathered from a senior who currently works there. He then asked if I had attended the Pre-Placement Talk (PPT). I answered honestly that while I had joined the session, I was traveling and couldn't pay full attention.
- **Motivation:** He asked the classic question, "Why do you want to work at Citi?"
- **Future Aspirations:** He asked, "Where do you see yourself in the future?"
- **Personal Interests:** My resume mentioned an award in football. As a fellow football enthusiast, the HR manager started a friendly discussion about the sport, which helped build a good rapport.

Conclusion & Feedback

As the interview concluded, the HR manager gave me two key pieces of feedback:

1. He advised that I should research a company more thoroughly before an interview.
2. He shared that my technical interviewer had given "great feedback" on my performance. I asked him to pass on my thanks.

I left the interview a little worried that my answer about the company wasn't strong enough. However, the results were announced an hour later.

Final Result

Out of the 11 candidates who made it to the final round, 7 were selected for the internship, including me.

General Tips

1. Be strong in DSA, DBMS, OOP, and OS.
2. Create a clear resume and know every detail on it.
3. Prepare explanations for your projects and a short pitch for each skill.
4. Be honest and show them you are a capable candidate.

All the very best!!

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